MERCY'S ANATOMY

Document MA-011: The World of Mercy's Anatomy, to July 1, 2005

Canon Lock v2.6. The United States, New York City, and the people and places of our story

STATUS: LOCKED IN. *Mercy's Anatomy* takes place in the **real United States**, with its real history, laws, prices, technology and events up to **Friday, July 1, 2005** (S1E1), and moving forward in real time after that. On top of that real world sits **our fictional layer**: the Donohue dynasty, the Victor Donohue Foundation, Queens Grace Hospital, Hudson Mercy, and every character in MA-005. Where the two meet, reality holds, except where this document deliberately says our world differs (§2).

1. The Two Layers

The real world (unchanged)	Our fictional layer (added)
U.S. presidents, Congress, courts, wars, elections and laws	The Donohue-Mercer-Bullock dynasty and its $200B family fortune
Real NYC: mayors, subways, neighborhoods, landmarks, weather	Queens Grace Hospital (1889), One Grace Plaza, LIC
Real news outlets (NYT, Daily News, Post, Newsday, NY1, Queens Chronicle)	The Victor Donohue Foundation ($300B), the Donohue Award, the Mercer Scholars
Real tech timeline (MySpace, RAZR, BlackBerry, YouTube in 2005)	The Donohue Valve (1971), as part of the world's real medical history
Real medicine: ACGME rules, HIPAA, drugs, devices, procedures	Hudson Mercy Medical Center (Jersey City, 1911)
Real pop culture, sports and music	Monty's on Jackson, QueensGraceConfidential, and every character

2. Where Our World Differs from Ours

- **The richest family on earth is the Donohues.** In this world, the Donohue family's $200 billion (2005) makes them the wealthiest family in the world, ahead of every real fortune. Business magazines have tried for years to estimate it and keep getting it low.
- **The largest foundation on earth is the Victor Donohue Foundation.** At $300 billion it is many times larger than any real foundation, and it fills the Harper Avery Foundation's role (C-049).
- **The Donohue Valve is a real medical milestone.** It's in every cardiac surgery textbook in this world. Every surgeon knows the name Donohue, and almost none know what Marc-Anthony Bullock's grandfather looks like.

- **'The Route 49 Doctor'.** Victor's 1958 loading-dock surgery on Elijah Tate was covered by the Black press at the time, and it's a civil-rights-era legend that Black medical students learn.
- **Queens Grace exists.** It's a real-feeling 1889 safety-net hospital in western Queens, sitting alongside New York's real hospitals, which are never criticized by name.

3. The United States on July 1, 2005

Area	State of the country
Government	President George W. Bush, second term (inaugurated Thursday, January 20, 2005). Vice President Dick Cheney. Republican Congress.
Wars	Iraq (since March 20, 2003) and Afghanistan. Army surgeons rotate through combat hospitals. This is Rod Maddox's world, and later Harmony's.
Firsts	Condoleezza Rice became Secretary of State (January 26, 2005). Barack Obama was sworn in as U.S. Senator from Illinois (January 4, 2005), the only Black senator. In New York, Willie Randolph is in his first season managing the Mets, the first Black manager of a New York baseball team.
Today's news	On Friday, July 1, 2005, Justice Sandra Day O'Connor announces her retirement from the Supreme Court. Live 8 concerts are set for tomorrow, July 2.
Economy	The housing boom is in full swing. Gas is about $2.20 a gallon. The federal minimum wage is $5.15; New York's is $6.00.
Health care	About 46 million Americans are uninsured. Medicare Part D (prescription drugs) starts January 1, 2006. HIPAA has been in force since 2003. Vioxx was withdrawn in September 2004. Fights over malpractice insurance are everywhere.
Medical ethics	Terri Schiavo died on March 31, 2005, after a national end-of-life fight. Stem cell research is divided by federal limits (2001) and California's Proposition 71 (2004). Fears of avian flu are rising.
Black America	Black physicians are a small fraction of U.S. doctors, a gap the Freedmen's Fund and the Mercer Scholars exist to close. The 1997 federal apology for the Tuskegee syphilis study is still fresh in patients' memories, and so is the distrust.
Rights	Same-sex marriage is legal only in Massachusetts (since May 17, 2004). DOMA (1996) is federal law.
Culture	At the movies this summer: *Batman Begins* (June 15), *Star Wars: Episode III* (May 19), *War of the Worlds* (June 29). On TV: *Lost*, *Desperate Housewives*, *American Idol* (Carrie Underwood won in May). On the radio: Mariah Carey's 'We Belong Together' rules the summer.
Tech	Motorola RAZR flip phones; BlackBerrys for attendings; iPods; AIM away messages; MySpace for everyone; Facebook for college students only; YouTube is months old; Google Maps launched in February. No iPhone (2007) and no Twitter (2006).

4. New York City, Summer 2005

- **Leadership:** Mayor Michael Bloomberg is running for re-election (the vote is November 8, 2005). Governor George Pataki. Senators Hillary Clinton and Chuck Schumer. Queens Borough President Helen Marshall.
- **Mood:** four years after 9/11, the city is rebuilding, and the Freedom Tower design is still being fought over. The West Side Stadium plan died on June 6, 2005, and the city's 2012 Olympic bid will lose to London on July 6.

- **Life:** the bar smoking ban has been in effect since 2003 (Monty's on Jackson is smoke-free and the regulars still complain). A MetroCard ride costs $2.00. Summer heat waves and humid nights.
- **Queens:** the most diverse county in America. Long Island City is mid-transformation: factories, 5Pointz, Silvercup Studios and the Pepsi-Cola sign beside new glass towers, with the 2001 rezoning pricing out QGH's own patients.

Mid-2005 New York prices (typical; for scene realism)

Item	Price
Subway or bus ride (MetroCard)	$2.00
Slice of pizza	$2.00-2.50
Bodega coffee, regular	$0.75-1.00
First-class stamp	$0.37
Movie ticket (Manhattan)	~$10.50
Gallon of gas (NYC)	~$2.30
1-bedroom rent, Long Island City	~$1,500-1,800 / month
Motorola RAZR (with contract)	~$199
QGH intern salary (PGY-1)	$44,820 / year

5. Where Our People Live (July 1, 2005)

Character	Home	Notes
Marc-Anthony Bullock	**The House on 49th Avenue**: an 1890s three-story brick rowhouse in Hunters Point, ten minutes' walk from QGH	Victor and Joan's first New York home (bought in 1960). It's held in a Mercer family trust, so the deed reveals nothing. Marc takes in intern roommates: Harmony and Raven move in during Season 1. It's the counterpart of Meredith's house.
Amond Baker	A bare studio in Sunnyside, Queens	A mattress, a laptop, a cactus. He's barely there.
Esther Smilley	A 1978 sailboat named *Clarence*, docked at the World's Fair Marina, Flushing Bay	A liveaboard: her counterpart's trailer on the water. She bikes or takes the 7 train to work.
Arianna Cummings	A rented room above a Greek bakery in Astoria	Cheap, loud, and it smells like heaven at 4 AM.
Harmony Divine	Her parents' house in Cambria Heights, then the House on 49th Avenue	She moves out of her family home for the first time, at 26.
Raven Ellison	A sublet in Ridgewood, then the House on 49th Avenue	She arrives with one suitcase and a hot-comb kit.
Elxa Bullock and Russell Jeffries	A two-family house in St. Albans, Queens	They rent the downstairs unit to a retired NYPD detective.
Natasha Donohue and Robert Bullock	A Riverside Drive brownstone on the Upper West Side	Bought in 1993. Robert drives a 1987 Mercedes he refuses to replace.
Victor Donohue and Joan Mercer	Donohue House, Brookline, Massachusetts	Where the Foundation was chartered.
Grace Bullock	An apartment near Harvard Medical School, Boston	Until July 2007.

6. Real-World Event Calendar for Continuity

Real events the story will meet as it moves forward. Each is honored in the season it falls in (MA-001 §8).

Date	Event	Season	Story relevance
Jul. 7, 2005	London bombings	1	The news in the residents' lounge
Aug. 29, 2005	Hurricane Katrina	1-2	Elxa's 28th birthday; the Toussaint family; the Foundation's $6B pledge
Oct. 24, 2005	Rosa Parks dies	2	Grandma Jo's grief; a hospital moment of silence

Date	Event	Season	Story relevance
Dec. 20-22, 2005	NYC transit strike	2	Staff walk the Queensboro Bridge to work
Sept. 26, 2006	Facebook opens to everyone	3	The secret-identity threat level rises
Jun. 29, 2007	The iPhone launches	3-4	Tech shift; photos everywhere
Sept. 15, 2008	Lehman Brothers collapses	5	The QGH deficit becomes a crisis, leading to the merger
Nov. 4, 2008	Obama elected	5	A night on the Roof
Mar. 23, 2010	Affordable Care Act signed	6	The payer-mix politics of the merger
Jul. 24, 2011	Same-sex marriage legal in New York	8	Camille and Autumn, and every couple who waited
Oct. 29, 2012	Hurricane Sandy floods Long Island City	9	A storm and evacuation episode at the renamed hospital
Apr. 15, 2013	Boston Marathon bombing	9	The Donohue family's home city
Jun. 26, 2015	Obergefell v. Hodges	11	Marriage equality nationwide
Mar. 2020 onward	COVID-19 pandemic (NYC as the epicenter)	16-17	The counterpart's pandemic season
May 25, 2020	George Floyd murdered	16-17	A reckoning across the all-Black cast's world
Jun. 24, 2022	Dobbs decision	18-19	Esther, Grace and OB/GYN on the front line

7. How the World Talks (2005 Slang and Usage)

- **Everyday:** 'my bad,' 'for real,' 'that's crazy,' 'I'm dead' (meaning hilarious), 'off the chain,' 'holla at me,' 'it's whatever,' 'crunk,' 'bling' (already a little dated), 'fo' shizzle' (strictly ironic).
- **Hospital:** 'scut,' 'pimping' (attendings quizzing interns), 'GOMER,' 'circling the drain,' 'the Pit,' 'Gracelings,' 'the Board,' 'call room,' 'bounce-back,' 'turf' (to push a patient to another service).
- **Never in 2005:** 'tweet,' 'selfie,' 'app' (as a phone word), 'FaceTime,' 'stan,' 'no cap,' 'slay' (in its modern sense), 'lowkey' (in its modern sense). Slang moves forward with the calendar.

8. On Air: The Morning of S1E1

NY1 MORNING HEADLINES, Friday, July 1, 2005, 5:00 AM (in-world)

• Supreme Court Justice Sandra Day O'Connor expected to address her future today.
• Heat advisory for the five boroughs this weekend; Fourth of July fireworks set for the East River.
• New York's 2012 Olympic bid enters its final week before the IOC vote.
• **LONG ISLAND CITY:** Queens Grace Hospital welcomes a new class of surgical interns this morning with its rooftop 'Dawn Oath,' a tradition dating to 1968.
• **BOSTON:** the Victor Donohue Foundation closes its fiscal year with a record $18.9 billion in charitable spending.

O'Connor's announcement came later that morning. The anchor's 'expected' line keeps it timing-accurate at 5:00 AM.

9. Canon Log Additions

ID	Established fact	Source
C-063	The story world is the real United States, with real history to July 1, 2005, plus our fictional layer. Reality holds except where MA-011 §2 says otherwise.	MA-011
C-064	In this world, the Donohues are the richest family on earth and the Foundation is the largest foundation. The Donohue Valve is real medical history.	MA-011 §2
C-065	Marc lives at the House on 49th Avenue in Hunters Point (a Mercer trust property). Harmony and Raven move in during Season 1.	MA-011 §5
C-066	Esther lives aboard the sailboat Clarence at the World's Fair Marina, Flushing Bay.	MA-011 §5
C-067	The real-world event calendar (MA-011 §6) is binding for continuity.	MA-011 §6

END OF MA-011. CANON LOCKED (v2.6). The world is set. It's 5:30 AM on July 1, 2005, and the interns are climbing to the Roof.